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THE ORCHARD

Shane Thomas Strough

El Gringo Clandestino

*"It is the particular blindness
of a woman who had to build her own survival."*

"I will water your garden until the day I die."

— from the poem

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The Palmarcito Papers

She sent a twenty-one-second video
at 10:26 on a Monday night—
just her fingers lifting a green leaf
she had refused to let die.

You'll have to show me, she said,
because I don't see it.

It is the particular blindness
of a woman who had to build her own survival.
When your hands have lived in the dirt
for seventeen years,
when you have pulled your world tight
just to keep the perimeter from failing,
you do not see the scale of what you've grown.
You see the labor.
You see the fences.
You see the weather.
You see what nearly died
and had to be kept alive anyway.

Seventeen years ago, she was a flower—
beautiful enough to stop a man where he stood.
But what she became in the silence,
what she built in the years
he was not there to witness,
is an orchard.

Not delicate.

Not decorative.

An orchard.

Deep-rooted.

Bearing.

Self-sustaining in the old hard way.

A living structure

that feeds more than itself.

A thing that learned weather

because weather would not stop coming.

A thing that survived loss

because surviving was the only road left open.

Please don't problem solve me, she told him.

I want a life, not an obligation.

So he did not come toward her

with blueprints and repair language.

He did not reach for the fences

as if love were ownership.

He did not speak like a man

trying to claim the harvest

because he happened to admire the fruit.

He looked at the orchard.

He looked at the woman who had raised it.

And he said the only worthy thing:

**I will water your garden
until the day I die.**

Not: I will save you.

Not: I will come in hard

and make it easy.

Not: hand me the whole field

and I will call it mine.

Only this:
I will stand beside what you built.
I will carry the water.
On the days you cannot see the orchard,
I will tend the root.
On the days you can,
I will keep carrying the water.

I will not confuse love with management.
I will not call control devotion.
I will not mistake your strength
for an invitation to leave you thirsty.

Because that is what a real vow sounds like
after weather.
Not ownership.
Not rescue.
Not a man arriving to conquer
what already learned how to live without him.

A man arriving with water.
A steady hand.
A long patience.
A willingness to kneel beside the living thing
and serve what is already growing.

She does not see it yet.
She does not have to.
That is what the water is for.

— Shane Thomas Strough / El Gringo Clandestino / Palmarcito, El Salvador / 2026